

have ravaged Congo since the 1990s. Throughout his career, Mukwege has treated tens of thousands of women subjected to sexual violence. In 2018, he was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize for “his efforts to end the use of sexual violence as a weapon of war and armed conflict.”

“When he came to Oslo for the award ceremony, he invited me to come with him, and there we had a conversation. He was receiving one of the biggest awards in the world, but he asked me, ‘Your mother told me you are quitting football. Is it true?’” Bakenga recalls.

“I said, ‘Yes. I’ve had enough of the game. I don’t enjoy it anymore, and now that my Achilles has ruptured for the second time, I’ve lost my speed. That was everything I had.’ He said, ‘Okay, so what are you going to do?’ I replied, ‘I already have a job.’ That was true because I had been studying sports management and was almost into that field,” Bakenga explains.

“He told me that wouldn’t be the best use of my abilities. He said I could accomplish much more in my current path. He then pointed out one of the women doctors who had accompanied him to the Nobel Awards in Oslo. He told me her story. She had been raped when she was a child, and here I was feeling sorry for myself after two surgeries on my foot! This woman had undergone 20 surgeries.

My uncle had treated her when she was just 13 years old. Eleven years later, she had studied and become a doctor herself. She was now working with him, helping women navigate the trauma she had once endured.

Then he looked me in the eye and said, ‘I’m not saying you have to think the same way, but don’t give up living your life because you’re feeling sorry for yourself,’” Bakenga recalls.

Six years after that conversation, Bakenga is still playing football. He currently plays as a striker for the table-topper Punjab FC in the Indian Super League. However, inspired by his uncle, Bakenga is doing much more than just playing football.

Award winner

Bakenga was on his way to a training session in New Delhi a couple of weeks ago when he received a call from a friend who worked at FIFPRO — the global union for professional football players.

His friend wanted to know if Bakenga was available the following week to attend the World Football Summit in Sevilla. He informed Bakenga that he was going to be presented with the Marcus Rashford Award, which recognises athletes who have promoted initiatives and efforts that bring about positive change in their communities.

The award was presented to Bakenga for developing a school for an orphanage of over 1,000 children in the Democratic Republic of Congo, called College Namugunga — named after his grandfather, Samuel Namugunga. Jabez World, the organisation Bakenga founded, fundraises and supports the needs of the school.

Until then, the 32-year-old striker had no idea he was even up for the award. Although his professional commitments in the ISL meant that his sister collected the award on his behalf, he is grateful for the recognition. “I didn’t even know I was nominated. It was a big surprise, but I felt a sense of pride. I hope this award will help to shine more light on the cause I am working for. I really hope it brings more people to come and help me,” he says.

While the Norwegian international now hopes to bring more attention and resources to his project, there was a time when he wanted very little to do with the country. Bakenga

comes from an educated family — his aunts and uncles are doctors, politicians, and pastors. His mother worked with UNICEF, and although he was born in Trondheim, Norway, he would visit Congo during school vacations. When he was four years old, a civil war broke out. The First Congo War claimed a quarter of a million lives and displaced many hundreds of thousands more.

Targeted in civil war

Bakenga’s family in the city of Bukavu, in eastern Congo, was among those affected by the conflict. The experience left him with mental scars that are still healing. “I remember all that happened, but for a long time, I repressed it. It’s the kind of thing a child shouldn’t see or experience,” he says. “As a family that was educated and outspoken, we were always targeted. We were constantly hiding from soldiers, sometimes in the forest. For two years, all we did was try to survive. I remember one episode where my family was in a school building. All of a sudden, we learned that the fighters were almost there. They were literally coming in tanks. We went from laughing and playing to hiding in these small spaces we had created. I was just four years old at the time. We had babies and children even younger than me. I remember my mother covering my nose and mouth with her hand so I wouldn’t make a sound. I was so quiet, and I remember how close those soldiers came to finding us. I could see their feet and hear their voices. They were looking for someone to shoot or kidnap,” he says.



‘At our home in Bukavu, I had a stuffed teddy bear in my room. I had to leave it behind when we were fleeing. One day, I was able to return home and ran back to my room to see my teddy bear again. But I found it riddled with bullets. I get goosebumps every time I remember this.’